English Language practice paper 1: answers and marks

How to mark your paper. Question 1 is marked point by point. Questions 2, 3 and 4 are marked as a whole: read your answer, then pick the description that fits it best. Compare your answer with "What a top answer might say" and the list of things you could write about. You don't need all of them: two or three explained well beats a long list.

Write your mark next to each question, then add them up. Read the "Watch out" boxes even when you did well: they're the mistakes that cost people marks in the real exam.

Question 1

4 marks

Read again the first part of the source, from lines 1 to 5. List four things about the town from this part of the source.

The answer

Any four of these (they must come from lines 1 to 5): the shops pulled down their shutters; the fish and chip shop turned its sign to Closed; gulls sat hunched on the railings; the gulls had their backs to the wind; the lifeboat station still had its lights on; the promenade was grey; it was four o'clock (the town had given up on the day).

How the marks are given

- 1 mark for each true thing about the town, up to 4 marks.

Watch out

- Only use lines 1 to 5. Anything about the sea or the storm (line 6 onwards) gets no mark.
- Short answers are fine. Copying the right words from the text counts.

Question 2

8 marks

Look in detail at this extract, from lines 9 to 16 of the source. How does the writer use language here to describe the storm? You could include the writer's choice of: words and phrases; language features and techniques; sentence forms.

> The storm came in from the west like a closing door. First the light went, drained out of the sky as if someone had pulled a plug. Then the rain arrived, not falling but thrown, flung sideways in fistfuls that rattled against the harbour wall. The waves stood up, grey and heavy, and threw themselves at the stones again and again, as though they had a grudge to settle. Spray burst over the wall in great white sheets. The wind screamed through the masts of the moored boats, and every rope and chain in the harbour began to clang and shriek.

What a top answer might say

The writer makes the storm sound sudden and violent, almost like an attacker. The simile "like a closing door" makes it feel sudden and final, as if Nell is being shut in with no way out. The verbs "thrown" and "flung" suggest the rain is being hurled at her on purpose, and "fistfuls" makes it sound like someone punching. The writer personifies the waves, which "stood up" and "threw themselves at the stones" "as though they had a grudge to settle": the sea seems angry and alive. Sound words like "screamed", "clang" and "shriek" fill the harbour with noise, which builds a sense of panic. The sentences follow the storm step by step ("First the light went… Then the rain arrived"), so the reader feels it getting worse.

How the marks are given

This question is marked as a whole. Read your answer, then pick the description that fits it best.

7 to 8 marks	You look closely at the writer's choices and explain their effects in detail. Your quotes are short and well chosen, and you use the right terms (simile, personification, verb and so on) accurately.
5 to 6 marks	You clearly explain the effects of the writer's choices. Your quotes fit what you're saying, and you use some terms accurately.
3 to 4 marks	You try to say what effect the writer's choices have. You use some quotes, and some terms, but not always accurately.
1 to 2 marks	You make simple comments, or you spot a feature or quote without saying what effect it has.
0 marks	Nothing written about the writer's choices.

Things you could write about

- The simile "like a closing door": sudden, final, trapped
- "drained out of the sky as if someone had pulled a plug": the light vanishes fast
- Verbs "thrown", "flung" and the noun "fistfuls": violent, deliberate, like being hit
- Personification of the waves: "stood up", "threw themselves", "a grudge to settle": angry, alive, threatening
- Sound: "screamed", "clang and shriek": noise, panic
- Sentence forms: "First… Then…" builds the storm in stages; long sentences pile up the chaos

Watch out

- Always say what effect the words have on the reader. "This is a simile" on its own gets very little.
- Use short quotes, a few words long, and explain the key word.

Question 3

8 marks

You now need to think about the whole of the source. This text is from the opening of a short story. How has the writer structured the text to interest you as a reader? You could write

about: what the writer focuses your attention on at the beginning; how and why the writer changes this focus as the source develops; any other structural features that interest you.

What a top answer might say

At the start, the writer gives us a wide view of the town shutting down for the day, which sets a gloomy, empty mood. The focus then moves out to the sea changing colour, which hints that something bad is coming, and the storm arrives. The one-line paragraph "Nell pulled her hood tighter and stayed where she was" zooms in on Nell and shows she is stubborn. We find out why she's there (Kieran is on the ferry), then the flashback to the hot day in August contrasts sharply with the storm and shows how much she misses him. The writer then brings us back to the present with short time markers, "Twenty to five. Then quarter to", which build tension. We see danger through other people: the harbour master doesn't wave and the lifeboat crew run. The ending stops on a tiny light, so we don't know if Kieran is safe, which makes us want to read on.

How the marks are given

This question is marked as a whole. Read your answer, then pick the description that fits it best.

7 to 8 marks	You explain in detail how and why the writer moves the focus, and how this keeps the reader interested. You choose good examples from all through the source and use the right terms (shift, flashback, short paragraph and so on) accurately.
5 to 6 marks	You clearly explain how the writer changes the focus and the effect this has, with relevant examples and some accurate terms.
3 to 4 marks	You try to say how the text is put together, with some examples, but you don't always say why.
1 to 2 marks	You make simple comments, maybe just retelling what happens in order.
0 marks	Nothing written about structure.

Things you could write about

- Beginning: a wide view of the town closing up: gloomy setting
- The sea changing colour: a warning of what's coming
- The storm: the focus narrows in
- One-line paragraph (line 17): zooms in on Nell, shows she's stubborn
- Background: Kieran, the ferry, her birthday
- Flashback to August: hot, happy, a contrast with the storm
- Time markers "Twenty to five. Then quarter to.": waiting, tension
- Danger shown through others: the harbour master, the lifeboat crew
- Repetition "Mum had told her a lot of things" and "She told herself a lot of things"
- Ending on the light: a cliffhanger, we don't know what happens

Watch out

- Structure means how the text is put together and why: where it starts, where the focus moves, and how it ends. It isn't about single words: save those for Question 2.
- Don't just retell the story in order. Say why the writer moved the focus.

Question 4

20 marks

Focus this part of your answer on the second part of the source, from line 33 to the end. A student said: "In this part of the story, the writer makes us feel Nell's fear really strongly, but also gives us a bit of hope. It's as if we're waiting on the wall with her." To what extent do you agree? In your response, you could: consider your own impressions of Nell's feelings; evaluate how the writer has created these impressions; support your response with references to the text.

What a top answer might say

I mostly agree. The fear is very strong: the writer shows it through other people first, as the harbour master "did not wave to her" and "just stared", and the lifeboat crew are "running", so we realise before Nell says anything that something is wrong. Her body gives her away too: "Her heart was hammering", so loud "she could feel it in her ears". The repetition of "She told herself" shows she is trying to calm herself down, but the more she says it, the less we believe it. I agree there is some hope, but it's small and uncertain: the light is "so small that at first she thought she had imagined it", and "It rose, and fell, and rose again" could be the ferry or the lifeboat. We do feel as if we're waiting with her, because the short time markers slow everything down, and the last line, "did not dare to blink", leaves us holding our breath too.

How the marks are given

This question is marked as a whole. Read your answer, then pick the description that fits it best.

16 to 20 marks	You judge how far you agree and explain why in detail, with a clear view of your own. You pick out exactly how the writer creates the feelings, with short, well-chosen quotes from all through this part.
11 to 15 marks	You clearly say how far you agree and explain the writer's methods, with relevant quotes.
6 to 10 marks	You give some opinion and try to explain how the writer creates it, with some quotes.
1 to 5 marks	You give a simple opinion, or mostly retell what happens, with little reference to the text.
0 marks	Nothing relevant.

Things you could write about

- Say how far you agree, and keep coming back to the statement
- Fear: the harbour master not waving, "just stared", the radio
- Fear: the lifeboat crew running, pulling on helmets
- Fear: "Her heart was hammering", "feel it in her ears"

- Repetition "She told herself…": she's trying to believe it, and we don't
- Hope: the light, "rose, and fell, and rose again": small, fragile, uncertain
- Waiting with her: time markers, short sentences, the last line "did not dare to blink"

Watch out

- Only use line 33 to the end.
- "To what extent" means you can agree, disagree or partly agree. Say what you think, then prove it with quotes and explain how the writer did it.

Total: 40 marks. A rough guide for this practice paper: 30 or more is a strong result. 20 to 29 is solid, with some gaps to fix. Under 20 means going back over Questions 2 to 4 in the notebook first. Whatever you got, write down where you lost marks: that's what to revise next.